guarantees, which includes the promise to conduct a caste survey—a cause that leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi is trying his best to champion (see *The Freebie Flurry*). It's against this breathless action-laden background that the Selja episode has given the BJP a fresh plank to reach out to the Dalits.

WHY HARYANA IS CRUCIAL FOR THE BJP

For the BJP, a loss in Haryana could have far-reaching consequences, especially with elections in Maharashtra, Jharkhand and Delhi lined up in the coming months. A win in the Jat heartland, on the other hand, will take some heat off the saffron party, which has been facing farmers' ire for quite some time and is struggling to win back the narrative in neighbouring Uttar Pradesh after a lacklustre performance in the Lok Sabha election. Moreover, after Punjab and Himachal Pradesh, the BJP can ill afford to lose another state in the region. In that sense, Haryana also acts as a bulwark for New Delhi, explains a top BJP leader. Earlier this year, when Punjab farmers again wanted to lay siege to the national capital, they were stopped by the Haryana Police at the state's border in Ambala. Else, he says, it could have turned into another headache for the Centre just like the prolonged stir on Delhi's borders in 2020-21 that forced a repeal of the farm laws.

Retaining power in Haryana has other strategic advantages as well. India's fastest developing investment destinations—Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Chennai—are all in Opposition-ruled states. The next in line is Mumbai, where the BJP and its allies are facing an uphill task to retain power. This leaves Haryana as a major linchpin in the BJP's Viksit Bharat dream. For, it is home to Gurugram and Faridabad, major investment hubs in Delhi NCR and north India along with Noida in UP. But most of all, it had its salience as a key part of an unbroken saffron landscape.

Those halcyon days are over—the BJP is experimenting with making this election more localised. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has addressed only two rallies so far and is likely to hold just a couple more before campaigning ends on October 3. Even Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini and his guru and predecessor Khattar have not been given a free hand. Though Saini is slated to address 90-odd rallies, other saffron satraps like Rao Inderjit Singh, Anil Vij, Dharambir Singh and Krishan Pal Gurjar have also been allowed to campaign extensively, keeping alive their hopes for the CM's post.

Even the Congress has refrained from anointing Hooda as its chief ministerial choice, despite allowing him to pick candidates and design the campaign. Hooda, leader of the Opposition and a former two-time CM, was instrumental in mobilising Jat support in the Congress's favour in the Lok Sabha election. Jats, who comprise about a fourth of the state's population, also exert an influence over other communities. The Congress has sought to take ownership of the triad of themes close to the Jat voter's heart—seeking justice for the *pehelwan* (wrestlers), *kisan* (farmers) and *jawan* (Agniveers, in this case). The idea is to cash in on the dominant community's resentment towards the BJP—building since the appointment of Khattar, a Punjabi Khatri, as CM in 2014 and compounded by the violent Jat quota agitation of 2016, waves of farmer protests and, more recently, the wrestlers' stir in Delhi.

But BJP insiders insist Jat anger is limited to only two regions of the state—Deshwal in central Haryana and Bagar in the west (see *The Poll Kurukshetra*). The BJP hopes that the INLD and the JJP—with their new Dalit alliance partners, the BSP and the ASP—will have some residual sup-



X @BHUPINDERSHOODA

Led by Hooda, the Congress is trying to champion the cause of the *pehelwan, kisan* and *jawan*, close to the Jat voter's heart